

# Faith Accompli

A community of camel-breeders worships a British officer killed in Rajasthan during the 1857 upsurge



RABARIS PRAYING AT THE PLATFORM IN AUWA

By Rohit Parihar

**A**s a group of Rabaris, camel-breeders from Rajasthan, bow reverently to a platform at village Auwa in Pali district of Rajasthan, faith triumphs yet again over reason. Amid the ruins of cenotaphs of Thakur nobles from this village, they come to this place with prayers on their lips for a British officer who was beheaded by local fighters in the great revolutionary upsurge that shook India in 1857.

Captain George Henry Monck Mason of the Bengal Native Infantry, who was also the political agent of Jodhpur, fulfils wishes, according to local belief. Mason, 33, is believed to have been killed on September 18, 1857, and his head displayed at the fort's gate during a battle between the British forces and Auwa's then Thakur, Khushal Singh. The Thakur had rebelled against the Maharaja of Jodhpur. Even Karl Marx wrote then in the *New York Tribune*: "They have defeated considerable force which the Rajah of Todhpore (Jodhpur) had sent against them, killing the general and Captain Monck Mason and capturing three guns."

Nobody knows who constructed the plain-looking platform at the Mason's grave, which shows no signs of

any British inscription or architecture, but the Rabaris began offering prayers here on festivals. Says Pushpendra Singh Champawat, the present Thakur of Auwa: "My grandfather Nahar Singh, recalling his ancestors' version, had declared this to be the place where Mason was buried." Later, a Jain trader rebuilt the platform. A search on the Internet reveals the existence of a tablet with an inscription on Mason's killing by Auwa's mutineers at the St. James' Church in Delhi, and a white marble inscription on the Monck Mason family in a Wicklow cemetery which bears his name. His place of burial, though, finds no mention anywhere.

Minza Ram Raika places yellow flowers on the platform, which also has an engraved stone placed on it, portraying a mounted warrior-turned-deity. The faithful are convinced the engraving is of a hat-wearing Mason with a kilted soldier standing next to him.

The Rabaris sing songs lauding the British. One says, "The English brought an iron cart that could run on rails without bullocks. Oh Britons, your skills were too great!" As Singh joins them with folded hands, they light incense and offer a coconut. Faith, truly, knows no reason. ■